



Tiny Tool Brief

Turn one small frustration into a useful, testable personal tool.

No coding experience required. Use synthetic or non-sensitive examples.

The smallest useful version wins

This is a thinking aid, not a product plan. Spend about 10 minutes on it. If the idea grows, remove a feature before adding one.

1 Notice the friction

What did you copy, paste, reformat, look up, calculate, rename, or repeatedly click more than twice last week?
I repeatedly...

2 Describe one small job

This tool is for: *me / another person*

When this happens:

I will give it this input:

It will give me this useful output:

3 Make version one tiny

Version one must:

Version one will not:

I will know it is useful when:

4 Give one concrete example

Use made-up, public, or low-sensitivity data.

Example input:

Expected output:

5 Check the boundaries

- What data would leave my device, and where would it go?
- How will I notice a wrong result?
- Can it change, delete, publish, purchase, submit, or send anything?
- Who besides me could be affected?
- What should it refuse to do?

One important boundary:

6 Test before polishing

Normal case: *the everyday example*

Edge case: *blank, duplicate, unusually long, or oddly formatted*

Safe-failure case: *reject, leave unchanged, or ask for confirmation*

7 Choose the next 15-minute action

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Remove one feature from the brief. | ☐ Investigate a privacy, permission, or policy question first. |
| ☐ Ask an AI assistant to challenge the brief. | ☐ Use an existing feature instead of building this. |
| ☐ Try the normal example in a prototype. | ☐ Stop: this is not useful or safe enough to pursue. |

30-second sanity check

Explain your idea out loud in one sentence. Then ask: What could version one leave out? If the answer is 'nothing', the idea is probably still too large.

Use AI as a cautious prototyping partner

Paste only information you are permitted to share. These prompts deliberately ask for fewer features, explicit tests, and a chance to stop.

LANE A | Refine the brief

Act as a cautious prototyping partner. I am designing a tiny personal tool, not a commercial product. Read my brief below.

1. Restate the job in one sentence.
2. Identify assumptions or vague words that would make the result hard to test.
3. Suggest what version one can omit.
4. Propose one normal test, one edge-case test, and one safe-failure test using synthetic data.
5. Flag privacy, permission, reliability, or maintenance concerns.
6. Recommend the simplest suitable form: an existing feature, reusable prompt, spreadsheet formula, template, single local webpage, script, or extension.

Do not write code yet. Ask at most one essential question.

MY BRIEF

[Paste the brief here. Do not include sensitive or confidential information.]

LANE B | Try a local prototype

Help me build the smallest useful version of the brief below for personal use. Create one self-contained HTML file using plain HTML, CSS, and JavaScript. It must work locally when I open the file in a browser. Use no server, packages, external libraries, analytics, network requests, accounts, or API keys. Keep the interface accessible and simple.

Before the code, restate the input, output, and assumptions briefly. Then give the complete file and simple save/open instructions. Include three manual test cases: normal, edge, and safe failure. Do not add features that are not in the brief. If this form is unsuitable or unsafe, explain why instead of forcing it.

MY BRIEF

[Paste the brief here. Use only synthetic or permitted data.]

From local page to Firefox prototype

A normal local webpage is a successful first step. Wrap it as an extension only after its behaviour has been tested.

Start with one dashboard tile

Three tasks | today's intention | a countdown | a few useful links. Ask for only one tile in the first prototype.

LANE C | Wrap a tested dashboard

Turn my tested local dashboard into a minimal Firefox Manifest V3 extension that replaces the new-tab page. Keep the existing behaviour and plain HTML, CSS, and JavaScript. Use no framework, build tools, remote scripts, analytics, or unrequested features. Request only permissions that are strictly necessary and explain each permission in plain language.

Give the complete files and instructions for temporary installation through about:debugging. Clearly explain that temporary installation ends when Firefox restarts and that persistent installation in standard Firefox requires Mozilla signing. Include a test that confirms saved information appears in a second new tab.

MY TESTED DASHBOARD
[Paste or attach the permitted files here.]

Keep the sequence boring

- 1 Build the smallest local version.
- 2 Test normal, edge, and safe-failure cases.
- 3 Only then add packaging, permissions, or another feature.

Good enough is a valid finish line. A tiny tool should earn its maintenance cost, not become a new hobby by accident.